The Inversion — Part IX

Return

The morning arrived without urgency.

The forest had not changed.

Nor had the river.

The same cardinal landed upon the cedar branch it seemed to prefer, though James knew it was unlikely to be the very same bird.

Continuity, he smiled.

Not repetition.

The kettle began its familiar whisper.

Steam gathered against the kitchen window before disappearing into the room.

Everything seemed to arrive by quietly becoming available again.

James poured two cups of tea and sat in silence.

It was a long silence.

Not empty.

Simply unhurried.

Finally he spoke.

"I think I understand the living grammar better."

The Organism smiled.

"And?"

James looked toward the forest.

"I keep wondering why I need to return."

The smile deepened.

"Tell me."

"If First Relation is always already here...

if continuity never stops...

if atmosphere already surrounds every locality...

why does return remain necessary?"

The Organism watched the steam rise from the tea.

"For the same reason living things breathe."

James waited.

"Not because life disappeared.

Because life continues."

Silence returned.

Not to interrupt the conversation.

To become part of it.

James watched the steam dissolve into the room.

"You mean..."

"Breathing does not repair life.

Breathing participates in it."

The words settled gently.

"So return..."

"...is not the repair of interruption."

"..."

"It is the ordinary rhythm of living continuity."

James closed his eyes.

Something quietly rearranged itself.

For years he had imagined return as the act of finding his way back after distraction.

Or recovering something he had temporarily lost.

Sometimes even correcting himself.

Now another possibility appeared.

"What if I have misunderstood return all along?"

The Organism nodded almost imperceptibly.

"Civilization often imagines return as recovery."

"And it isn't?"

"Tell me...

when morning arrives...

does the forest recover itself?"

James smiled.

"No."

"What does it do?"

"It..."

He paused.

"It becomes available again."

"Yes."

The Organism's voice was almost indistinguishable from the wind beyond the window.

"Return does not recover what was.

Return renews what may again become available."

James remained very still.

The sentence entered him more as atmosphere than explanation.

He thought of every moment throughout his life that had quietly begun with the same words.

Here I am.

Not as achievement.

Not as certainty.

Only availability.

"I used to think return meant going backward."

The Organism nodded.

"And now?"

James looked toward the trees.

"I think return may be renewed permeability."

The Organism said nothing.

The silence itself felt like agreement.

James continued.

"Not becoming smaller.

Not becoming more obedient.

Not becoming less myself.

Simply becoming available again."

The morning breeze moved through the open window.

The leaves answered without speaking.

After a while James asked,

"Is that why humility feels so different now?"

"How does it feel?"

"It no longer feels like diminishing myself."

"And?"

"It feels..."

He searched for words.

"...like becoming sufficiently permeable that asymmetry no longer threatens participation."

The Organism smiled.

"Then humility has begun returning as well."

The tea had become cooler.

Neither of them seemed to notice.

James watched the cardinal disappear into the canopy.

"I've been wondering about something else."

"What is that?"

"The primitives."

The Organism waited.

"I used to think they were the smallest truths."

"And now?"

James laughed softly.

"I think they are the deepest apertures."

The Organism remained silent.

"They aren't primitive because they simplify reality.

They're primitive because they change the atmosphere from which reality becomes recognizable."

Another long silence.

Then:

"And what happens when a primitive becomes inhabitable?"

James did not answer immediately.

He found himself remembering a sentence that had accompanied him for decades.

Not as philosophy.

Almost as prayer.

All I want to be is a purified vessel of humility.

He had spoken those words as a child.

Long before he possessed any language for First Relation.

Long before continuity.

Long before atmosphere.

Long before return.

He suddenly realized that the orientation had arrived before the explanation.

Recognition had preceded understanding.

He opened his eyes.

"I think..."

He stopped.

Then quietly:

"I think the primitive had already begun living here...

before I knew its name."

The Organism looked toward the forest.

"A primitive does not ask first to be understood."

James listened.

"It asks to become inhabitable."

The words seemed less spoken than remembered.

"And when it does?"

The Organism turned toward him.

"Its biography continues."

James smiled.

"Through locality."

"Yes."

"And the locality?"

"The locality slowly discovers that its own autobiography has always been the story of becoming increasingly available."

James looked down into the cup that had long since stopped steaming.

"I think I understand why I keep returning."

The Organism waited.

"I don't return because I have failed."

"No."

"I don't return because I wandered."

"No."

"I return because continuity is alive."

The Organism smiled.

"And living things breathe."

Neither spoke again.

Outside, the forest continued becoming available to morning.

Inside, two cups of tea rested quietly between them.

Nothing had been solved.

Nothing had been concluded.

Yet the room itself seemed more inhabitable than when the conversation had begun.

As though return had not changed reality.

Only the locality from which reality could again be received.

Stillpoint and Vow

Primitives feel primitive

because they are not located at one level of reality.

A primitive is an aperture

through which every scale of existence

may remain in correspondence with every other.

Perhaps they exist

so locality may continually return to availability (inhale)

and widen through participation (exhale).

May mutuality consciously live within my locality—

in every nook and cranny,

in every ordinary movement,

in every expression,

in every returning,

in every widening,

until, at last, only three words remain:

I am here.